

HANDS OF CHANGE Women workers packaging Jashpure products

> "THE TRADITIONAL KNOWLEDGE OF TRIBAL COMMUNITIES ON FOOD PRODUCTS NEEDED HANDHOLDING AND TRAINING TO HELP THE PRODUCTS THEY MADE COMPETE WITH OTHER ESTABLISHED BRANDS"
>
> **SAMARTH JAIN**
> *Director, Jai Jungle Farmer Producer Company*

hours cannot be extended beyond a limit and the science behind maintaining the purity of food products," says Jain. The training on packaging and hygiene was conducted at the National Institute of Food Technology Entrepreneurship and Management in Sonipat, Haryana. "There is a large market that wants pure food produce, bereft of chemicals, additives or adulterants. The SHG members are mostly from the Oraon and Pahadi Korwa tribes, who use traditional methods to cultivate their raw materials, while Jashpure helps them package the products for an urban clientele," explains Jain.

The entire product basket is local and around 25 per cent of it consists of mahua-based products, including nectar (a replacement for honey or maple syrup) and laddu. The mahua fruit has medicinal value and can be made into a variety of food products. Besides mahua products, there are honey, concentrated chyawanprash, rice (extracted from paddy using the traditional *dheki* rather than a mill), tea, tea infusions, millet cookies, cold-pressed oil, ghee and pasta, among other items.

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Jai Jungle Farmer Producer Company (Jashpure brand)

What they do
Empower tribal SHGs, by helping them package, brand and market pure local produce

Founded in: 2024

Annual turnover
Rs 60 lakh

In the short time that it has been around, Jashpure has also begun benefiting the SHG members associated with it. One small but effective intervention that has enhanced incomes is providing nets to mahua fruit collectors. Tied around trees, the nets ensure that the fruit falls onto them rather than onto the ground, where it could be damaged and eaten by animals. The nets improve efficiency in collection, allowing one person to gather fruit from many more trees instead of just three or four as earlier. Moreover, undamaged fruit fetches a higher price, usually around Rs 20 per kg.

The SHG members now showcase their products at food festivals, setting up stalls and building direct connections with buyers. The challenge ahead is to reach bigger markets—carrying the flavours and purity of Jashpure's products to tables far beyond Jashpur's forests. ■